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Culture (OWC): [Ovambo \(FX08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1947-1948

Coverage Date: 1928 AD - 1948 AD

Place Coverage: North-Central Namibia

Section Title(S): Kinship Customs . • Puberty Rites .

Kinship Customs.

Cross-cousin marriages are frequent. They cause the Catholic Mission in Ukuambi Land much trouble, since the Catholic Church will not solemnize such marriages. Cross-cousins who call each other "bull" stand in a joking and bundling relationship. My informant, an educated school teacher, explained that a man is supposed to take his father's sister's daughter as his first wife, because through her he can inherit from his father. Then as a second wife or as one of his later wives he may marry his mother's brother's daughter.³

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The mother-in-law taboo is very strict for a man, even if he is a Christian. An engaged man will hide behind a tree when he sees his fiancée's mother approaching. He will not talk to her. After marriage, however, he is merely respectful to his mother-in-law; and after the birth of his first child he will speak freely to her, although he will not eat with her. But if a man marries his cross-cousin his relationship with his mother-in-law is less formal; he keeps on calling her kuku or memegona, and he is not shy. Similarly, a man may not eat with his father-in-law unless he has married a cross-cousin. The same taboos govern the behavior of a woman and her parents-in-law of the opposite

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Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

sex, unless she has married a cross-cousin. Here parents-in-law is used as it is by the Kuanyama in the classificatory sense of relatives by marriage belonging to the father's or an earlier generation.

The Ukuambi are the only Ambo of those we studied who have a special title and a special function for the father's sister. Among all the Ambo the mother's brother acts more or less as a male mother and is more lenient than the actual father to his nephews and nieces; but among the Ukuambi a young person has also a tate kadi, his father's sister, who acts as a female father and watches over his well-being. She is not expected to punish him, however; for either his father or his mother's brother disciplines him. In some ways she is like a boy's mother, too; she allows him, for instance, to go into her pantry and take anything he wishes.

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Twins (epasa) are important members of their families. The Ukuambi regard them very highly and celebrate their birth in an extended festival. After the parents are purified with water and herbs, there is dancing for a month. The father carries the twins to the royal kraal to be shown to the king, who makes them a gift of cattle.

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Puberty Rites.

The Ukuambi no longer have circumcision rites. The ohango for the girls takes only six days. Two men, a namaganga (medicine man) and an omupitisi (leader) conduct the rites. A small drum rather than a kudu horn wakens the girls in the morning. The omupitisi dresses them in their belts. Until recently a girl found to be pregnant at the time of the ohango had to submit to an abortion or be put to death. Probably this custom  285 is now prohibited; yet the Ukuambi have been so conservative a tribe that as lately as 1934 Lebzelter could write:

"For years the only salvation of these [pregnant] girls was flight to the mission station. I found Ukuambi girls in almost all the mission stations in the country."⁴

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3. This is a native theory, and not one held by the author. I believe that in a matrilineal society the tendency is toward a patrilateral form of marriage (e.g., to the father's sister's daughter); in a patrilineal society, toward a matrilineal form of marriage (e.g., to the mother's brother's daughter). The Ukuambi are a matrilineal agricultural society overlayed by a cattle-raising patrilineal society. The forms of marriage are primarily determined by psychological and not economic motivations. See Loeb and Toffelmier, 1939, p. 184.

4. Lebzelter, loc. cit., p. 33.

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